

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

A. The patient is at risk for double depression.

B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.

C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.

D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

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Finding Reasoning Paths :

- 1 . **Sad ness , hope lessness , and an hed onia** â Major Dep ressive Disorder (MDD) â Risk of " double depression " .
- 2 . **Guilt and suic id ality** â Chronic depressive symptoms + acute depressive episode â Major Depressive Disorder .
- 3 . **Poor concentration and energy** â Symptoms of depression â Major Dep ressive Disorder .
- 4 . **Hope lessness and suicidal ide ations** â Se vere depression â Major Dep ressive Disorder .
- 5 . **Dyst hym ia or persistent depressive disorder** â Chronic depressive symptoms â Risk of " double depression " with acute depressive episodes .

Reasoning Process :

1 . **Symptom Analysis** :

- The patient has a history of sadness dating back to childhood and describes a sense of hope lessness and guilt . These are hallmark symptoms of **persistent depressive disorder (dyst hym ia)** , which is a chronic condition .
- The acute symptoms of **po or concentration , an hed onia , and suicidal ide ations** over the past 2 weeks suggest an **acute depressive episode** on top of the chronic depressive symptoms .
- The combination of chronic depressive symptoms (dyst hym ia) and acute depressive symptoms (major depressive episode) is referred to as **double depression** .

2 . **Differential Diagnosis** :

- The symptoms do not align with other conditions such as **attention-deficit/hyper activity disorder (ADHD)** , **reduced consciousness/confusion** , or **Alzheimer disease** . These conditions are not supported by the clinical presentation .
- The symptoms are best explained by a diagnosis of **Major Dep ressive Disorder (MDD)** with a history of **persistent depressive disorder (dyst hym ia)** .

3 . **Risk of Double Depression** :

- Double depression occurs when a patient has a history of chronic depressive symptoms (e .g . , dyst h ym ia) and experiences one or more acute depressive episodes (e .g . , MDD) over the course of their lifetime .
- The patientâs history of long -standing sadness and current symptoms strongly suggest this diagnosis .

4 . **Treatment Considerations** :

- Effective treatment for double depression often involves **combination therapy** , including pharmac ological treatments (e .g . , SSR Is , SN R Is) and psychotherapy (e .g . , cognitive-be havior al therapy , or CBT) .

Conclusion :

The patient is at risk for **double depression** , characterized by the co existence of chronic depressive symptoms (dyst hym ia) and acute depressive episodes (MDD) .

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The patient is at risk for double depression .

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